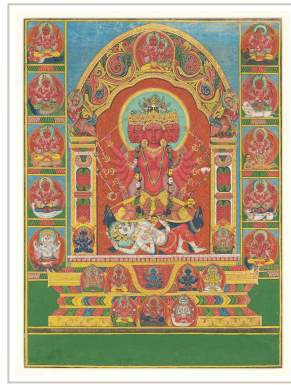


T A N T R A Y A

Supplementary Workbook · The Ten Mahavidyas

Tripura Sundari

Beauty of the Three Worlds



Tripura Sundari, Lalita, Empress of the Three Worlds

Third of the Mahavidyas · Foremost Deity of Sri Vidya

Also known as Lalitā, Ṣoḍaśī, Rājarājeśvarī

Practice through the five senses

Tantraya · Sacred Valley of Peru

At a Glance

RANK	Third of the ten Mahavidyas
TRADITION	Presiding deity of Sri Vidya and the Sri Chakra, foremost of the Mahavidyas in the Srikula lineage
NAME MEANS	“Beautiful one of the three cities,” or “three worlds”
OTHER NAMES	Lalitā (“she who plays”), Ṣoḍaśī (“the ever-sixteen-year-old”), Rājarājeśvarī (“queen of queens”)
FORM	Young, radiant, dusky-red or golden, seated at the centre of the Sri Chakra
FOCUS OF THESE PRACTICES	The five senses as direct doorways to beauty beyond conditioning

The Myth

Her clearest myth begins with Kamadeva, the god of desire, burned to ash by Shiva in a moment of ascetic fury. From those ashes rises the demon Bhandasura, who goes on to drain the vital essence, the rasa, out of all three worlds, leaving them barren. The gods respond by performing a great sacrifice, offering their own bodies and the seven oceans into a fire lit from the very flame of consciousness itself. From that fire, Lalitā Tripura Sundari emerges, fully formed, to destroy Bhandasura and restore what he had drained from creation.

The shape of the story is worth noting on its own. Desire is destroyed, and out of what is left of it, something drains the vitality from the world. What restores that vitality is a beauty that rises directly out of the fire of awareness, not the return of desire in its old form.

Symbolism and Image

Her primary form is a geometric diagram rather than a figure at all, the Sri Chakra: nine interlocking triangles surrounding a single central point, the bindu. Four of the triangles

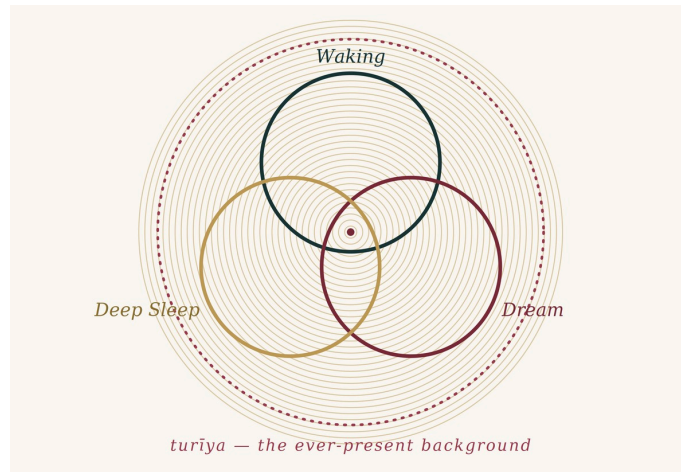
point upward, representing Shiva. Five point downward, representing Shakti. At the centre, where all of them converge, is the bindu itself, the point where the manifest universe and its unmanifest source meet. She is the presiding deity of this entire diagram, and in Sri Vidya practice the diagram itself is treated as her subtle form, arguably closer to her true nature than any pictured image of a goddess could be.

Her epithet *Ṣoḍaśī*, “sixteen,” is worth holding alongside the practices below. She is pictured as eternally sixteen, and is said to embody sixteen kinds of desire, held at the peak of youth rather than in decline, in its full, unashamed range rather than denied or transcended. This matters for a course built entirely around the senses: nothing here asks you to move past sensation toward something higher. The invitation is to find what is already complete within sensation itself.

Understanding the Energy

The “three cities” in her name are read on more than one level. Literally, they are three worlds: heaven, earth, the underworld. Understood inwardly, they are the three ordinary states of consciousness: waking, dreaming, and deep dreamless sleep. Tripura Sundari is described as ruling all three, yet she stands apart from any single one of them. She is identified with *turiya*, the fourth state: the background present through all three, never itself absent even when each state comes and goes.

This is the real key to why her practices are built around the senses rather than around any single myth or practice. Sight, sound, smell, taste, and touch are the specific instruments through which the three ordinary states get filled with content: objects seen, sounds heard, things wanted or avoided. What these practices ask you to notice is something underneath all of that content: a beauty that is not dependent on your particular likes, culture, or conditioning, closer to *turiya* than to any state that judgment or preference could touch. The senses are not obstacles to get past here. They are the doorways she has found in.



Waking, dream, and deep sleep, held within turiya, never itself absent

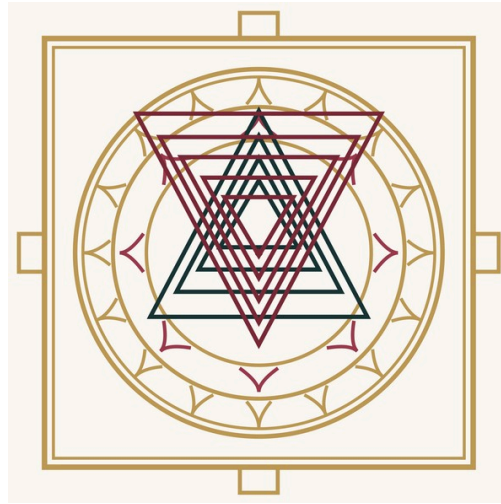
How to Work With These Practices

Nearly everyone treats beauty as a judgment, this is beautiful, that is not, based on standards absorbed so early and so completely they feel like direct perception rather than conditioning. These practices work to loosen that.

The method is not to argue yourself out of your preferences, and not to tell yourself your preferences are wrong. It is to show yourself, directly and repeatedly, through the senses, how much of what you call beautiful or ugly shifts depending on era, culture, and circumstance, and how much stays present underneath all of that shifting once you actually look. The senses are the place to do this work, because they are where the conditioning is most convincing and most invisible.

Do all five sense-practices every day, but give one sense your full attention each day, and let that sense colour how you move through the rest of your day too: really looking for what is beautiful through sight on the sight day, really listening for it on the sound day, and so on.

Practices



The Sri Yantra: nine interlocking triangles around the central bindu

Tripura Sundari's practices work through the five senses directly, because the senses are exactly where conditioning about beauty is most convincing and most invisible. Nothing here asks you to move past sensation toward something higher. The invitation is to find what is already complete within sensation itself, before preference and culture finish shaping what you are allowed to call beautiful.

Give one sense your full attention each day, letting it colour how you move through the rest of that day, then close with mind itself and a seventh practice that gathers what all five have shown you.

Practice One – Working with Sight

Across time. Gather images of people considered beautiful across different eras, as far back as you can find, decade by decade, up to now, and notice how much what is called beautiful has shifted.

Across culture. Do the same across cultures, and let yourself notice your own reactions to practices unfamiliar to you, like foot-binding or neck-rings, without editing those reactions.

Saint and celebrity. Look at an image of someone widely regarded as a saint and ask what makes them beautiful, then compare that to a conventional celebrity image. What is actually different?

Flower and weed. Look at a flower, then at a weed, and ask honestly why one gets called beautiful and the other does not.

The overlooked. Look at a run-down building, broken pottery, a wrinkled face, and let beauty become visible there without forcing it.

Form itself. Separately, study form itself: shape, colour, geometry, texture, light and shadow, how the parts relate to each other, and notice how each contributes to what you experience as visually beautiful.

Practice Two – Working with Sound

Five genres. Listen to a piece of death metal, a classical piece, a pop song, a song you genuinely love, and a devotional song, one after another. Notice what triggers judgment and preference, and try to find something true and beautiful in each one, even the ones you dislike.

Pure listening. Spend ten to fifteen minutes simply listening to whatever sounds arise around you, without naming, judging, or reaching for anything. Notice that the ear itself just receives, and that judgment is a separate layer arriving right afterward.

The unpleasant sound. Listen to a genuinely unpleasant sound and notice the body's urge to tense against it. Try listening without that contraction.

Ordinary sound as music. Listen closely to birdsong and to ordinary background noise, footsteps, traffic, and ask what you would hear if you treated it as music.

Practice Three – Working with Smell

Blind scent. If you can, have someone else gather a range of smells and offer them to you blindfolded one at a time. Notice your immediate reaction, attraction or rejection, and then notice what memory or association shows up right after, and how closely the two are linked.

Layers of incense. Spend five minutes with a beautiful incense or oil, paying attention to its different layers rather than just an overall impression.

Practice Four – Working with Taste

Blind taste. Blindfolded, if possible, have someone offer you a range of different tastes and notice your reactions.

Slow melt. Let a piece of something you enjoy melt slowly on your tongue and notice everything that contributes to the sense of it being beautiful. Then notice the pull to want more of it, and see how long the experience of that beauty actually lasts on its own, without needing to be repeated.

Practice Five – Working with Touch

Range of texture. Gather a range of textures and touch each one lightly, noticing which you are drawn to and which you resist, even though the touch itself is the same gesture each time.

Your own skin. Pay attention to your own skin, how warm, alive, and responsive it actually is, and let yourself enjoy something like a hot shower or a warm bath fully.

The elements. Feel wind, rain, sun, or cold directly on your skin and notice the richness of that contact with the world.

Practice Six – Working with Mind

Goodness, truth, beauty. Read a little of the Platonic idea that goodness, truth, and beauty are ultimately one thing, and sit with that idea rather than rushing past it.

Beauty and consciousness. Notice how all human-made beauty, poetry, art, music, passes through the mind to exist at all, and consider what that says about beauty's relationship to consciousness itself.

Practice Seven – Turiya, the Background Present Throughout

Practice. Sit quietly and let waking awareness settle. Ask directly what has been present through every sense-practice so far. Set aside the sights, sounds, smells, tastes, and textures themselves, and look instead for whatever it is that has been aware of all of them equally, without preferring one sense's content over another. Rest attention there rather than on any object of the senses.

Evening reflection. Having worked through all five senses, what beauty showed up in every single one of them, regardless of which sense delivered it?

Advanced Exercises

The Reversal. Take something you find genuinely ugly and spend ten minutes looking for what is beautiful in it specifically, found directly through its ugliness rather than in spite of it. Do the same in reverse with something you find conventionally beautiful: look for what is ordinary or unremarkable underneath the polish.

The Stranger's Beauty. Look closely at a stranger, someone outside your usual type or standard, and deliberately search for what is beautiful in their particular face, without comparing it to anyone else's.

Sixteen Desires. List sixteen things you genuinely desire, small or large, sensory or otherwise, without judging any of them as base or unworthy. Notice which ones you were taught to be ashamed of, and sit with that shame directly rather than resolving it.

The Deeper Principle

Tripura Sundari's myth begins with desire destroyed and the world drained of its vitality as a direct result. What restores that vitality is not desire's return in its old form. It is a beauty that rises out of the very fire of consciousness that destroyed desire in the first place.

This is the precise reason her practices refuse to ask you to transcend the senses. Sodashi, eternally sixteen, holds sixteen kinds of desire at their peak rather than in denial or decline. The senses are not obstacles standing between a practitioner and something higher. They are the specific doorways she has always used to enter.

What these practices train is the capacity to find, underneath every conditioned preference about what counts as beautiful, a beauty that does not depend on era, culture, or personal history, closer to turiya, the fourth state present through waking, dream, and deep sleep alike, than to any judgment that comes and goes.

Her Faculty

If each Mahavidya develops one irreplaceable human capacity, Tripura Sundari's is the capacity to perceive beauty directly, prior to conditioning. Call it unconditioned delight: the ability to meet sight, sound, smell, taste, and touch, and find something genuinely beautiful there that has nothing to do with what you were trained to prefer.

This is a demanding capacity precisely because conditioning about beauty runs so deep it is mistaken for direct perception. Tripura Sundari's practices do not remove the conditioning. It teaches a student to look underneath it, again and again, until something steadier than preference becomes available.

Questions to Carry Through These Practices

- How much beauty is already here that I am not experiencing right now?
 - Why not?
 - What would let me experience it?
 - What is actually stopping me?
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Tantraya · Tools for Transformation